

6

COMMON DIET ANXIETIES

Eating habits that you suspect may not be right but still carry on with anyway

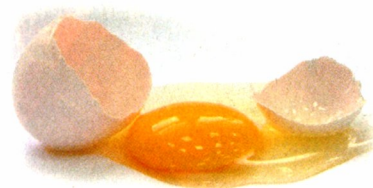


1 Can I drink diet soda every day?

A can or two isn't likely to hurt you. There's no credible evidence that the artificial sweeteners and chemicals in these cause cancer. But diet soda is not a health drink, although it saves you calories. One soda a day—regular or diet—increases your risk of obesity and type 2 diabetes. Go for fruit juice or skimmed milk. Or sip water through the day, with a squirt of lemon added for variety.

2 Are chicken eggs good or bad for cholesterol?

If you are healthy, the recommended dietary cholesterol limit is about 300 mg a day (200 mg if you have heart disease, diabetes or high blood cholesterol). One large egg has about 213 mg of cholesterol—all in the yolk. So it's perfectly fine if you eat an egg on a given day and limit other sources of cholesterol for the rest of the day. If you like eggs but don't want the extra cholesterol, use only the whites. They contain no cholesterol.



3 Is coffee good or bad for me?



Coffee doesn't seem to hurt and actually may help. No, it doesn't raise cancer or heart attack risk if consumed in moderation (no more than two cups a day). Four to seven cups a day, however, can cause restlessness, anxiety, irritability, sleeplessness and headaches. Coffee is believed to protect against Parkinson's disease, type 2 diabetes and liver cancer.

4 Is microwaving food in plastic containers harmful?

Although stories have circulated for years that microwaving plastic food containers or wraps causes them to release cancer-causing dioxins, this isn't thought to be true. Still, it's important to follow general safety guidelines: use containers or wraps labelled as "microwave-safe"; don't use carryout tubs, or paper or plastic grocery bags.

5 Does drinking water during or after a meal disturb digestion?

No. Water doesn't dilute the digestive juices or interfere with

digestion. In fact, drinking water during or after a meal can actually improve digestion. It helps break down the food in your stomach and keeps your digestive system on track.



6 How long can I safely keep leftovers in the fridge?



Eat refrigerated leftovers within four days to reduce the risk of food poisoning. For food safety, never allow perishable foods (meat, poultry, fish, dairy products and eggs) to sit more than two hours at room temperature. Your goal should be to minimise the time a food item is in the 'danger zone' (between 4°C and 60°C) when bacteria can multiply. Before eating leftovers, reheat them thoroughly. Cover foods with a lid or a microwave-safe plastic wrap to hold in moisture and provide safe, even heating.

Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**